



“There’s a genuine redefinition of ambition. Work still matters, often just after family, but proving commitment by staying late feels outdated”

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Most workplaces were designed decades ago for a completely different reality,” says Pune-based IT professional Dipin Bakshi.

One of the most damaging, he says, is gossip-driven leadership, where informal conversations and personal bias outweigh skills and performance. In one large organisation, Bakshi recalls, rumours became a quiet tool of power triggering self-doubt, anxiety, and a steady loss of confidence that eventually pushed him to seek therapy.

For Gen Z, he argues, silence only protects unhealthy systems. “Older generations believe staying quiet keeps the peace. But silence solves nothing. Speaking up isn’t disrespect, it’s responsibility,” he says, recalling how calling out unrealistic deadlines initially felt uncomfortable but ultimately helped his team.

Bakshi also challenges rigid hierarchies that treat authority as unquestionable. “The boss is not always right. Leadership should be collabor-

ative. Questioning isn’t rebellion it’s progress,” he says.

When it comes to well-being, Bakshi is clear that mental health cannot be separated from work itself. “Burnout comes from pressure, poor leadership, and unrealistic expectations.” His bottom line: “Gen Z isn’t rejecting work...we’re rejecting unhealthy work cultures.”

THE NEW WORKPLACE

At Mercedes-Benz Research and Development India (MBRDI), the shift from “human resources” to “human relations” reflects a deeper rethinking of what work should feel like for the next generation. According to Mahesh Medhekar, Vice President, human relations, the intent is to move away from transactional employment models and build a relationship-led culture grounded in trust, psychological safety, and shared purpose.

MBRDI operates a trust-based working model that gives employees

autonomy over where and how they work, without rigid mandates. For Zoomers, particularly in R&D and engineering roles, this autonomy is complemented by self-regulated leave practices, team-designed schedules, and opportunities for horizontal career movement to build skills across functions. The emphasis, Medhekar notes, is on outcomes, collaboration, and connection.

Besides, culture is critical. “MBRDI prioritises psychological safety and inclusive leadership, assessing managers on empowerment, agility, and purpose,” Medhekar explains.

Perhaps the most defining shift is Gen Z’s embrace of AI. Indeed’s report shows that 71% of Indian workers use AI to validate ideas, plan careers, or solve work problems.

Kumar believes AI is on track to become both invisible and indispensable. “AI will make growth more accessible,” he says. “Think about it—there was a time when email felt futuristic. Now it’s just... there. AI will follow that same path.”

Over the next few years, organisations that succeed with Gen Z will move beyond pay-led attraction to offer growth, purpose, and human-centred work. Learning, Das emphasises, must be positioned as a core organisational value embedded through mentorship, micro- and gamified learning, internal mobility, AI skill-building, and clear career paths within the organisation.

Equally important, says Das, is what leaders must actively unlearn. “Authority rooted in title must give way to credibility built on skills. Presenteeism must be replaced with outcomes. Annual reviews must evolve into real-time coaching.”

At its core, Gen Z is asking a simple question: does work fit into a full life or does life exist around work? The reset that Gen Z is pushing for may feel uncomfortable, but it is also the clearest blueprint for the future of work. **BT**